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Self-Coaching for Complex Leadership Challenges



In fast-moving environments, leaders often face high-stakes decisions before support becomes available. This article offers a practical, research-backed approach to navigating complexity with clarity and confidence, even when coaching isn't immediately within reach.

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Inspired by: Harvard Business Review "How to Coach Yourself Through Complex Problems" (September 2025)

Across industries, leaders are encountering rising complexity, tighter timelines, and greater expectations, yet organizational support systems haven't always kept pace. Research shows that many leaders hesitate to seek help due to cultural pressure, fear of appearing unprepared, or simple lack of access. HBR highlights a powerful alternative: self-coaching. When practiced intentionally, self-coaching equips leaders to pause, diagnose challenges, and move forward with steady judgment, especially when the situation is messy or politically sensitive.

Self-coaching does not replace executive coaching, but it offers leaders an immediate, practical toolset when navigating uncertainty. The SOLVE framework, developed through decades of leadership research, provides a structured method to break down complex issues, explore root causes, design context-aligned solutions, and reflect for continuous growth.

The SOLVE Framework for Self-Coaching

- State the Problem: Define the core issue in one or two sentences, naming both the problem and its impact.
- Open the Box: Diagnose what's happening beneath the surface using data, patterns, and honest reflection.
- Lay Out the Solution: Design a context-sensitive plan that fits the culture, people, and organizational realities.
- Venture Forth: Act while monitoring responses, adapting to resistance, bias, or unintended consequences.
- Elevate Your Learning: Reflect on what worked, what didn't, and how insights can strengthen your leadership.

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Mashar Perspective

In the GCC, leaders often carry responsibility not only for strategy and performance but also for relational harmony, reputation, and social expectation. Support is valued, yet many hesitate to ask for it, wanting to remain capable, independent, and composed. This makes self-coaching especially powerful in our region.

By pausing long enough to name the real issue, explore cultural dynamics, and consider respectful solutions, leaders can make decisions that honor both results and relationships. Self-coaching aligns with the region's emphasis on wisdom, reflection, and dignity, empowering leaders to act thoughtfully, preserve trust, and remain anchored during uncertainty.



Learn More

Review the original research and guidance that shaped the coaching ideas explored in this article.

Read "How to Coach Yourself Through Complex Problems" on Harvard Business Review



Related Mashar Program

Support your leadership growth when navigating complexity, high-stakes decisions, and sustained self-reflection.

Explore Executive & Leadership Coaching by Booking a Clarity call with Mashar's Lead Facilitator



Further Reading

Explore additional research-based insights on leadership and organizational challenges.

Explore More Insights on Harvard Business Review

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